

TIA Portfolio Guide & Evidence Collection Kit

A Comprehensive Guide for Texas Teachers Pursuing Teacher Incentive Allotment Designations

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Section 1: TIA Overview

What Is the Teacher Incentive Allotment?

The **Teacher Incentive Allotment (TIA)** is a Texas state program (House Bill 3, 2019) that allows districts to provide **permanent salary increases** to teachers who are designated as **Recognized, Exemplary, or Master** based on their effectiveness.

Unlike bonuses that come and go, TIA designations are:

- **Portable** — they follow you to any participating district in Texas
- **Permanent** — as long as you maintain the designation (redesignation every 5 years)
- **Funded by the state** — districts receive additional allotment funding per designated teacher

Designation Levels & Potential Salary Increases

Designation	Description	Approximate Annual Increase*
Recognized	Consistently effective teacher with strong student outcomes	\$3,000 – \$9,000
Exemplary	Highly effective teacher with exceptional results	\$6,000 – \$18,000
Master	Among the most effective educators in the state	\$9,000 – \$32,000

**Actual amounts vary by district and campus. Rural and high-needs campuses receive higher allotments.*

How the Funding Works

The state calculates allotment amounts based on:

1. **Your designation level** (Recognized/Exemplary/Master)
2. **Your campus socioeconomic profile** (higher funding for high-needs campuses)
3. **Your district's approved local designation system (LDS)**

Teachers at **rural and high-needs campuses** can earn significantly more — the state incentivizes keeping excellent teachers where they're needed most.

Who Is Eligible?

- All classroom teachers in Texas public schools
- Your district must have a **TEA-approved Local Designation System (LDS)**
- You must meet the criteria set by your district's system
- Both tested and non-tested subject teachers can participate

How Long Does It Take?

Most districts collect data over one full school year. The typical timeline:

- **Year 1:** Data collection (you're doing this now!)
- **Year 2:** District submits data to TEA → You receive your designation
- **Ongoing:** Designation lasts 5 years, then you redesignate

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Section 2: The Two Pillars

How TIA Designations Are Determined

Every TEA-approved Local Designation System must evaluate teachers on **two pillars**:

Pillar 1: Teacher Observation (Qualitative)

This is based on your **T-TESS (Texas Teacher Evaluation and Support System)** observation scores or an equivalent approved rubric.

What counts:

- Formal observations by trained appraisers
- Walkthroughs (if your district includes them in LDS)
- T-TESS domain scores (Planning, Instruction, Learning Environment, Professional Practices & Responsibilities)
- Post-observation conference ratings

Typical requirements by designation:

Designation	Typical T-TESS Requirement
Recognized	Average of "Accomplished" across observed domains
Exemplary	Average of "Accomplished" with some "Distinguished"
Master	Average of "Distinguished" across observed domains

Pillar 2: Student Growth (Quantitative)

This measures the **academic growth** of your students over time.

For STAAR-tested subjects:

- Student Growth Percentile (SGP) — how much your students grew compared to similar students statewide
- Individual student growth data from STAAR

For non-STAAR subjects:

- District-approved Student Learning Objectives (SLOs)
- Pre/post assessments with validated growth measures
- Portfolio-based evidence of student growth (district-specific)

Typical requirements by designation:

Designation	Typical Growth Requirement
Recognized	Above-average student growth (55th+ percentile)
Exemplary	Well above average (60th–70th+ percentile)
Master	Top-tier student growth (75th+ percentile)

The Weight Split

TEA requires that **both pillars** factor into the designation. Most districts weight them:

- **Observation:** 30–50% of the overall score
- **Student Growth:** 50–70% of the overall score

 **Key Takeaway:** You cannot earn a designation on observation scores alone OR growth data alone. You need strong performance in BOTH areas.

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Section 3: Building Your Portfolio — Step by Step

Your TIA Portfolio Roadmap

Even if your district doesn't require a formal "portfolio," building one helps you:

- Organize evidence for observation conversations
- Document student growth proactively
- Prepare for redesignation
- Build a professional artifact you'll use for years

Step 1: Know Your District's LDS (August)

Action Items:

- ☐ Obtain a copy of your district's TEA-approved Local Designation System document
- ☐ Identify the specific criteria for each designation level
- ☐ Note the observation rubric being used (T-TESS or alternative)
- ☐ Understand how student growth is measured in your subject/grade
- ☐ Identify deadlines for data submission
- ☐ Ask your administrator: "What evidence would be most helpful for my TIA data?"

Step 2: Establish Baseline Data (August–September)

Action Items:

- ☐ Administer pre-assessments for all units/courses
- ☐ Document pre-assessment data in a tracking system
- ☐ Set Student Learning Objectives (SLOs) if required
- ☐ Photograph/scan any relevant baseline student work samples

- ☐ Record beginning-of-year benchmark scores

Step 3: Collect Evidence Continuously (September–April)

Action Items:

- ☐ Save lesson plans that show differentiation and rigor
- ☐ Document student growth data after each assessment
- ☐ Keep a log of professional development attended
- ☐ Save examples of student work showing growth (before/after)
- ☐ Document parent/family communication
- ☐ Track participation in PLCs, committees, mentoring
- ☐ Save observation feedback and your reflections

Step 4: Prepare for Observations (Ongoing)

Action Items:

- ☐ Review T-TESS rubric before each observation window
- ☐ Plan lessons that demonstrate "Distinguished" indicators
- ☐ Prepare your classroom environment (word walls, data displays, student work)
- ☐ Have your pre-observation form completed thoroughly
- ☐ Practice your post-observation conference talking points

Step 5: Compile Growth Data (April–May)

Action Items:

- ☐ Administer post-assessments
- ☐ Calculate student growth (percentage growth, point growth)
- ☐ Create data visualizations (charts, graphs)
- ☐ Identify growth by subgroup (ELL, SpEd, etc.)
- ☐ Write a narrative summary of student growth
- ☐ Prepare comparison data (your students vs. campus/district averages if available)

Step 6: Assemble Your Portfolio (May–June)

Action Items:

- ☐ Organize all evidence by T-TESS domain
- ☐ Write reflective narratives for each domain
- ☐ Include student growth data with analysis
- ☐ Add professional development certificates
- ☐ Include letters of recommendation or peer feedback (optional)

- ☐ Submit any required documentation to your district
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Section 4: Evidence Collection Checklists

Organized by T-TESS Domain

Use these checklists to ensure you have evidence across all evaluated areas.

Domain 1: Planning

"The teacher designs clear, well-organized, sequential lessons that reflect best practice, align with standards, and are appropriate for diverse learners."

Evidence to Collect:

- ☐ Unit plans showing alignment to TEKS
- ☐ Lesson plans with clear objectives, activities, and assessments
- ☐ Evidence of backward design (starting with the end assessment)
- ☐ Differentiated lesson plans (ELL modifications, SpEd accommodations, GT extensions)
- ☐ Plans that integrate technology meaningfully
- ☐ Cross-curricular connection plans
- ☐ Plans that incorporate student interests or real-world applications
- ☐ Evidence of using data to inform planning (e.g., re-teach plans based on assessment results)
- ☐ Intervention group plans
- ☐ Plans showing scaffolding for complex tasks
- ☐ Evidence of collaboration with co-teachers, paraprofessionals, or specialists

Distinguished Indicators to Target:

- Plans are adjusted based on continuous analysis of student data
 - Lessons connect learning across disciplines
 - Students are involved in planning their own learning paths
-

Domain 2: Instruction

"The teacher uses a variety of instructional strategies to ensure student engagement and learning."

Evidence to Collect:

- ☐ Video clips of instruction (if allowed by district)
- ☐ Photographs of students engaged in learning activities
- ☐ Examples of higher-order questioning strategies used
- ☐ Student discussion protocols or Socratic seminar documentation
- ☐ Evidence of formative assessment during instruction (exit tickets, quick checks)
- ☐ Documentation of varied grouping strategies (whole group, small group, partners, independent)
- ☐ Technology integration evidence
- ☐ Evidence of real-world connections in instruction
- ☐ Student feedback on instruction (surveys, reflections)
- ☐ Examples of how you adjusted instruction mid-lesson based on student responses
- ☐ Documentation of academic vocabulary instruction

Distinguished Indicators to Target:

- Students take ownership of their learning
 - Instruction seamlessly adjusts based on real-time data
 - Students make connections across content areas independently
-

Domain 3: Learning Environment

"The teacher creates a classroom environment that is safe, organized, and focused on learning."

Evidence to Collect:

- ☐ Photographs of classroom setup (seating arrangement, learning stations)
- ☐ Photos of word walls, anchor charts, data walls
- ☐ Classroom management plan/procedures document
- ☐ Evidence of positive behavior systems
- ☐ Documentation of classroom routines and transitions
- ☐ Student voice/choice evidence (student-led activities, choice boards)
- ☐ Photos or documentation of student work displays
- ☐ Evidence of a culturally responsive classroom environment
- ☐ Morning meeting or community-building activity plans
- ☐ Seating arrangement rationale (flexible seating, strategic grouping)
- ☐ Safety protocols documentation

Distinguished Indicators to Target:

- Students self-manage and hold each other accountable
- The classroom functions as a student-led learning community

- Environment reflects student ownership (student-created displays, rules)

Domain 4: Professional Practices & Responsibilities

"The teacher demonstrates the standards of the profession and contributes to the school community."

Evidence to Collect:

- ☐ Professional development certificates and hours log
- ☐ PLC participation documentation (agendas, minutes, your contributions)
- ☐ Mentoring activities (formal or informal)
- ☐ Campus/district committee participation
- ☐ Parent/family communication log (emails, newsletters, conference notes)
- ☐ Participation in school events beyond the classroom
- ☐ Professional organization memberships
- ☐ Conference presentations or published work
- ☐ Peer observation notes (observing others or being observed)
- ☐ Self-reflection journals or documentation
- ☐ Evidence of implementing feedback from observations
- ☐ Documentation of advocating for students (ARD meetings, 504 meetings, etc.)
- ☐ Professional goal-setting documentation
- ☐ National Board Certification progress (if applicable)

Distinguished Indicators to Target:

- You lead professional learning for others
 - You actively mentor and develop other teachers
 - You contribute to school/district improvement initiatives
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Section 5: Month-by-Month Calendar

What to Collect and When

17 August: Foundation Setting

Focus: Set yourself up for success before students arrive

Task	Done?
Obtain your district's LDS criteria document	☐

- Review T-TESS rubric thoroughly ☐
 - Set up your evidence collection system (digital folder, binder, or both) ☐
 - Create folder structure: one folder per T-TESS domain ☐
 - Set up your student data tracking system ☐
 - Photograph your classroom setup ☐
 - Document your classroom management plan ☐
 - Write initial professional goals for the year ☐
 - Meet with your appraiser to discuss TIA goals ☐
 - Identify pre-assessments you'll use ☐
-

17 **September: Baseline Data**

Focus: Establish starting points and routines

Task	Done?
Administer and score pre-assessments	☐
Enter baseline data into your tracking system	☐
Set Student Learning Objectives (SLOs) if required	☐
Collect baseline student work samples	☐
Document your first unit plans with TEKS alignment	☐
Begin parent communication log	☐
Photograph classroom routines in action	☐
Document your first PLC contributions	☐
Start your professional development log	☐

17 **October: First Evidence Push**

Focus: Start actively collecting instructional evidence

Task	Done?
Save 2-3 strong lesson plans showing differentiation	☐
Document student engagement strategies with photos	☐
Save first unit assessment data	☐
Begin tracking student growth from pre-test	☐
Document any small group or intervention work	☐
Save evidence of parent conferences (fall conference season)	☐
Prepare for first formal observation (if this month)	☐
Collect evidence of technology integration	☐

17 **November: Observation Season**

Focus: Nail your formal observation; collect instructional evidence

Task	Done?
Complete pre-observation form thoroughly	☐
Plan a "Distinguished-level" lesson for observation	☐
Ensure classroom environment is showcase-ready	☐
Have student data visuals displayed or accessible	☐
Prepare post-observation talking points	☐
Save post-observation feedback and your reflection	☐
Document second unit assessment data	☐
Save examples of student work showing early growth	☐

17 **December: Mid-Year Check**

Focus: Reflect, organize, and identify gaps

Task	Done?
Administer mid-year assessments	☐
Calculate pre-test to mid-year growth	☐
Organize your evidence folders — what's missing?	☐
Update your student data tracker with mid-year scores	☐
Review your evidence against T-TESS domains — identify gaps	☐
Save first semester grades/data summary	☐
Document professional development attended (fall semester)	☐
Write a mid-year self-reflection	☐

17 **January: Strategic Planning**

Focus: Use first semester data to target second semester evidence

Task	Done?
Analyze mid-year data for growth trends	☐
Create intervention plans based on data (document these!)	☐
Plan second-semester units with data-driven adjustments	☐
Set second-semester growth targets	☐
Begin STAAR review/prep planning (tested subjects)	☐
Document any student re-grouping based on data	☐

Prepare for second observation window (if applicable) ☐

February: Deep Evidence Collection

Focus: Collect your strongest evidence this month

Task	Done?
Save 2-3 of your BEST lesson plans from the year	☐
Document student discussions or collaborative learning	☐
Photograph updated classroom environment	☐
Collect STAAR mock test data (if applicable)	☐
Document mentoring or leadership activities	☐
Save PLC data discussions and your contributions	☐
Collect student voice evidence (surveys, goal-setting docs)	☐
Document any curriculum writing or committee work	☐

March: STAAR Prep & Growth Push

Focus: Document the final growth push; STAAR prep evidence

Task	Done?
Administer second STAAR mock (if applicable)	☐
Compare mock STAAR scores to first mock — document growth	☐
Save evidence of targeted intervention groups	☐
Document differentiation strategies for test prep	☐
Save student goal-setting activities	☐
Document any after-school tutorials or extra support offered	☐
Collect evidence of real-world connections in instruction	☐

April: Final Data Collection

Focus: Wrap up data collection; prepare for post-assessments

Task	Done?
Administer post-assessments / final benchmarks	☐
Calculate full-year growth (pre-test to post-test)	☐
Create growth data visualizations (charts, graphs)	☐
Calculate growth by subgroup	☐
STAAR administration (if applicable)	☐

- Save any remaining instructional evidence ☐
 - Document spring parent conferences ☐
 - Complete professional development log for the year ☐
-

May: Portfolio Assembly

Focus: Compile, organize, and submit

Task	Done?
Organize all evidence by T-TESS domain	☐
Write reflective narrative for each domain	☐
Compile student growth data with analysis	☐
Create a growth summary document	☐
Include all professional development documentation	☐
Submit required documentation to district (check deadline!)	☐
Back up everything digitally	☐
Schedule meeting with appraiser for year-end conference	☐
Celebrate — you've done incredible work this year! 🎉	☐

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Section 6: Student Growth Documentation Templates

Template 1: Individual Student Growth Summary

Student Name: _____
Student ID: _____
Grade/Subject: _____
School Year: _____

ASSESSMENT DATA:

Assessment	Score	Date
Pre-Test	___/100	___/___/___
Unit 1	___/100	___/___/___
Unit 2	___/100	___/___/___
Unit 3	___/100	___/___/___
Mid-Year	___/100	___/___/___
Unit 4	___/100	___/___/___
Unit 5	___/100	___/___/___
Unit 6	___/100	___/___/___
Post-Test	___/100	___/___/___

STAAR Mock 1	___/100	___/___/___
STAAR Mock 2	___/100	___/___/___
STAAR/EOY	___/100	___/___/___

GROWTH CALCULATIONS:

- Pre-Test → Post-Test Growth: _____ points (_____%)
- Pre-Test → Mid-Year Growth: _____ points (_____%)
- Mid-Year → Post-Test Growth: _____ points (_____%)
- STAAR Mock 1 → Mock 2 Growth: _____ points (_____%)

STAAR READINESS LEVELS:

- BOY Projection: ☐ D ☐ A ☐ M ☐ MA
- MOY Projection: ☐ D ☐ A ☐ M ☐ MA
- Final/Actual: ☐ D ☐ A ☐ M ☐ MA

SUBGROUP(S): ☐ ELL ☐ SpEd ☐ GT ☐ 504 ☐ At-Risk ☐ Dyslexia

INTERVENTIONS PROVIDED:

GROWTH NARRATIVE:

Template 2: Class Growth Summary

Teacher: _____
 Subject/Grade: _____
 School Year: _____
 Total Students: _____

CLASS GROWTH OVERVIEW:

Metric	Value
Class Pre-Test Average	_____%
Class Post-Test Average	_____%
Average Point Growth	_____
Average % Growth	_____%
Median Growth	_____%
% Students w/ >20% Growth	_____%
% Students w/ >10% Growth	_____%
% Students w/ <10% Growth	_____%
% Students w/ Negative	_____%

STAAR READINESS DISTRIBUTION:

	BOY	EOY	Change
Masters:	___(___)%	___(___)%	_____
Meets:	___(___)%	___(___)%	_____
Approaches:	___(___)%	___(___)%	_____
Did Not Meet:	___(___)%	___(___)%	_____

SUBGROUP GROWTH COMPARISON:

Subgroup	Pre-Avg	Post-Avg	Avg Growth
All	_____ %	_____ %	_____ %
ELL	_____ %	_____ %	_____ %
SpEd	_____ %	_____ %	_____ %
GT	_____ %	_____ %	_____ %
At-Risk	_____ %	_____ %	_____ %
504	_____ %	_____ %	_____ %

NARRATIVE SUMMARY OF STUDENT GROWTH:

Template 3: Student Learning Objective (SLO) Documentation

Teacher: _____
 Subject/Grade: _____
 School Year: _____

SLO STATEMENT:

By [DATE], [PERCENTAGE]% of students will demonstrate [SPECIFIC MEASURABLE OUTCOME] as measured by [ASSESSMENT NAME], growing from an average baseline score of [BASELINE] to a target score of [TARGET].

SLO: _____

BASELINE DATA:

- Assessment used: _____
- Date administered: _____
- Class average baseline score: _____ %
- Score range: _____ % to _____ %
- Number of students below grade level: _____

INTERIM CHECK (MID-YEAR):

- Assessment used: _____
- Date administered: _____
- Class average: _____ %
- % of students on track to meet SLO: _____ %
- Adjustments made based on data: _____

FINAL RESULTS:

- Assessment used: _____
- Date administered: _____
- Class average final score: _____ %
- % of students who met SLO target: _____ %
- SLO MET? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Partially

REFLECTION:

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Section 7: Self-Assessment Rubric

Rate Yourself Honestly Before Your Appraiser Does

Use this rubric to identify your strengths and areas for targeted growth. Rate yourself on each T-TESS dimension.

Rating Scale

- **1 = Improvement Needed** — This is an area of significant growth
- **2 = Developing** — I'm working on this; it's inconsistent
- **3 = Proficient** — I do this consistently and effectively
- **4 = Accomplished** — This is a strength; I go beyond the basics
- **5 = Distinguished** — I'm a model for others in this area

Domain 1: Planning

Dimension	1	2	3	4	5	Evidence I Have
Standards-aligned objectives	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Appropriate assessments	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Data-driven planning	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Differentiation in plans	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Cross-curricular connections	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Student-centered design	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

My Domain 1 Average: _____ **Goal for improvement:**

Domain 2: Instruction

Dimension	1	2	3	4	5	Evidence I Have
Achieving lesson objectives	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Content knowledge & accuracy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

Communication with students	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Differentiated instruction	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Higher-order questioning	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Formative assessment use	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Student engagement	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Technology integration	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

My Domain 2 Average: _____ **Goal for improvement:**

Domain 3: Learning Environment

Dimension	1	2	3	4	5	Evidence I Have
Classroom culture & climate	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Student behavior management	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Routines & procedures	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Physical environment	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Student ownership & voice	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Mutual respect	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

My Domain 3 Average: _____ **Goal for improvement:**

Domain 4: Professional Practices & Responsibilities

Dimension	1	2	3	4	5	Evidence I Have
Professional growth	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
School community involvement	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Parent/family engagement	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Collaboration with colleagues	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Compliance & ethics	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	
Mentoring/leadership	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	

My Domain 4 Average: _____ **Goal for improvement:**

Overall Summary

Domain	My Average	Target for TIA
Planning	_____	Recognized: 4+ / Exemplary: 4.5+ / Master: 5

Instruction _____	Recognized: 4+ / Exemplary: 4.5+ / Master: 5
Learning Env. _____	Recognized: 4+ / Exemplary: 4.5+ / Master: 5
Prof. Practices _____	Recognized: 4+ / Exemplary: 4.5+ / Master: 5

My target designation: ☐ Recognized ☐ Exemplary ☐ Master

Areas of strength (keep doing these!):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Areas for growth (focus here!):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Action plan for growth areas:

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Section 8: Common Mistakes to Avoid

Mistake #1: Waiting Until Spring to Collect Evidence

Why it's a problem: By April, you've forgotten the great lesson you taught in October. Observations only capture snapshots — you need documentation across the full year.

What to do instead: Set a recurring calendar reminder every Friday: "Save 1 piece of TIA evidence." Even a quick phone photo of student work or a screenshot of your lesson plan counts.

Mistake #2: Only Focusing on Observations

Why it's a problem: Observations (Pillar 1) are only 30-50% of your TIA score. Student growth (Pillar 2) is the MAJORITY. A perfect observation score with mediocre growth data won't get you a designation.

What to do instead: Invest equal or more energy into tracking and improving student growth data. Use a data tracker (like our Student Growth Tracking Template!), analyze results after every assessment, and adjust instruction based on what you find.

Mistake #3: Not Understanding Your District's Specific LDS

Why it's a problem: Every district's Local Designation System is different. What counts for TIA in Dallas ISD may not count in Katy ISD. If you're collecting the wrong evidence or using the wrong growth measures, it won't matter how hard you work.

What to do instead: Get your district's LDS document in August. Read it. Highlight the specific criteria. Ask your administrator or HR department if anything is unclear. Don't assume — verify.

Mistake #4: Ignoring Subgroup Data

Why it's a problem: Growth for ALL students matters, including ELL, SpEd, and At-Risk subgroups. If your class average looks great but your ELL students aren't growing, that's a gap that will show up in your data.

What to do instead: Disaggregate your data by subgroup regularly. Celebrate subgroup wins. Address subgroup gaps proactively. Document the interventions you're providing for each subgroup.

Mistake #5: Not Pre-Assessing

Why it's a problem: You can't show growth without a starting point. If you skip the pre-assessment, you have no baseline data — and no way to prove your students grew.

What to do instead: Give a pre-assessment at the beginning of every unit AND at the beginning of the year. It doesn't have to be long — even 10 questions that mirror the post-assessment will work. Save the data!

Mistake #6: Teaching to the Middle

Why it's a problem: Growth measures reward moving ALL students, not just the ones in the middle. If your highest students plateau because they're bored and your lowest students don't grow because they need more support, your growth numbers suffer.

What to do instead: Differentiate intentionally. Document your differentiation plans. Show how you challenge GT students with extensions and support struggling students with scaffolding.

Mistake #7: Treating the Post-Observation Conference as a Formality

Why it's a problem: The post-conference is where your appraiser finalizes your T-TESS scores. If you just nod and say "That went well," you're missing a chance to advocate for a higher rating.

What to do instead: Come prepared with:

- Specific evidence of what went well (tie it to T-TESS indicators)
 - Context for anything that didn't go perfectly
 - Questions about how to improve
 - A growth-oriented mindset (appraisers LOVE teachers who reflect authentically)
-

Mistake #8: Not Communicating Your TIA Goals to Your Appraiser

Why it's a problem: Your appraiser may not know you're pursuing a TIA designation unless you tell them. They can't support you if they don't know what you're working toward.

What to do instead: Have an early-year conversation: "I'm working toward a [Recognized/Exemplary/Master] designation. Can we discuss what I should focus on?" Most appraisers want to help — but they need to know you're interested.

Mistake #9: Messy or Disorganized Evidence

Why it's a problem: Having evidence is only half the battle. If it's scattered across three apps, two binders, and your camera roll, you won't be able to find what you need when you need it.

What to do instead: Use ONE system. We recommend a Google Drive folder with subfolders for each T-TESS domain. Save files with clear naming conventions (e.g., "D2_Instruction_LessonPlan_Oct15.pdf").

Mistake #10: Giving Up After Year One

Why it's a problem: Many teachers don't get their desired designation the first year. Data collection is a skill that improves with practice. The first year teaches you what to do differently.

What to do instead: If you don't get the designation you wanted, ask for feedback. What was the gap? Was it growth data or observation scores? Use that information to target your efforts next year. Most successful Master-designated teachers didn't get there on the first try.

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Appendix: Quick Reference Card

TIA at a Glance

	Recognized	Exemplary	Master
Salary Increase	\$3K–\$9K	\$6K–\$18K	\$9K–\$32K
Observation Score	Accomplished	Accomplished+	Distinguished
Student Growth	Above Average	Well Above Avg	Top Tier
Portable?	 Yes	 Yes	 Yes
Duration	5 years	5 years	5 years

Evidence Collection Minimum Targets

Category	Minimum Pieces	Ideal
Lesson Plans	5	10+
Student Work Samples	10	20+
Data Tracking Evidence	3	6+
Professional Development	3	5+
Parent Communication	5	10+
PLC Documentation	3	6+
Self-Reflections	2	4+
Classroom Photos	5	10+

Key Deadlines to Know

- ☐ **August:** Obtain LDS document, set up evidence system
- ☐ **September:** Administer pre-assessments, set SLOs
- ☐ **December:** Mid-year data check, organize evidence
- ☐ **April:** Post-assessments, compile growth data

- ☐ **May:** Submit portfolio/documentation (check your district's specific deadline!)

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